

Zero Sum RPG Scenario: 003 - The Silent Algorithm



Real-World Inspiration

Based on the highly secretive world of High Frequency Trading (HFT) and the risk of algorithmic "flash crashes" engineered by hostile state actors.

Background

A rogue quantitative hedge fund has deployed an illegal, highly aggressive AI trading algorithm on a direct-access server physically located inside the Frankfurt Stock Exchange data center. The algorithm is designed to execute a cascading short-sell attack that will artificially crash the European energy market within 48 hours, enriching the Syndicate by billions.

The Zero Sum Twist

The server room is a sterile, hyper-secure environment. It uses an acoustic detection system. Any noise above 45 decibels (a loud whisper, a dropped tool, or heavy footsteps) triggers the silent alarm, locking the vault doors and deploying armed, gas-mask-wearing tactical response units. The players must infiltrate the data center, locate the specific server blade out of thousands of identical ones, and physically install a logic bomb without making a sound.

Zero Sum Consistency Matrix (ZSCM)

- **E (Lethality Expectation) = 7:** If the acoustic alarm trips, the response team uses lethal force and tear gas.
- **R (Resource Scarcity) = 8:** Players cannot use any standard breaching tools, explosives, or firearms due to the acoustic sensors.
- **I (Intel Asymmetry) = 5:** Finding the correct server blade requires high-level Tech checks on the fly.
- **D (Collateral Damage Risk) = 5:** The facility is mostly empty of civilians at night, but destroying the wrong server could crash innocent pension funds.

Total ZSCM Score = 25/30 (High Tension Stealth).

Key NPCs & Obstacles

- **The Acoustic Grid:** An ever-present environmental threat. Movement speed is halved.
- **The SysAdmin:** A single, overworked IT technician working the night shift who might wander into the aisle at any moment.

Objective

1. Bypass the biometric security at the data center entrance.
2. Navigate the server aisles in absolute silence.
3. Identify the rogue HFT blade.
4. Upload the counter-virus and extract before the morning shift arrives.